

# Contest Mindset and Diagnostic

*Student Strategy Card · keep this all term*

## Side 1 — The six core moves

| Move                        | Reach for it when you see...                                            | Do this                                                              |
|-----------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Draw it</b>              | Lengths, shapes, movement or a story with parts                         | Sketch it and label every number you are given.                      |
| <b>Tabulate it</b>          | Several cases, two quantities that change together, or 'how many ways'  | Make a table; one row per case, in order.                            |
| <b>Try a small case</b>     | Huge numbers, 'n', or a pattern you cannot see                          | Solve the same question with 1, 2, 3 — then look for the rule.       |
| <b>Work backward</b>        | You know the end result and the steps                                   | Start at the end and undo each step in reverse order.                |
| <b>Eliminate options</b>    | Five choices and a property you can test (even, multiple of 5, too big) | Cross out the options that fail the test before calculating.         |
| <b>Check reasonableness</b> | Every question, last 10 seconds                                         | Estimate. Is the size right? The units? Did I answer what was asked? |

## How Gauss is scored

| Part | Questions | Points each | Part total |
|------|-----------|-------------|------------|
| A    | 1-10      | 5           | 50         |
| B    | 11-20     | 6           | 60         |
| C    | 21-25     | 8           | 40         |
| All  | 25        |             | 150        |

**Parts A and B hold 110 of the 150 points (73%). Bank them first.**

## Side 2 — Error codes

| Code     | Name                   | It means...                                                |
|----------|------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>C</b> | Concept                | I did not know or misunderstood the idea.                  |
| <b>R</b> | Representation         | I drew the wrong diagram, table or equation — or none.     |
| <b>S</b> | Strategy               | I had the idea but chose a slow or wrong plan.             |
| <b>A</b> | Arithmetic             | A calculation slip.                                        |
| <b>V</b> | Visual/spatial         | I misread a diagram or trusted how it looked.              |
| <b>Q</b> | Question-reading       | I answered a different question (units, 'not', 'of what'). |
| <b>T</b> | Time                   | I ran out of time or rushed.                               |
| <b>K</b> | Knew-but-didn't-recall | I knew it but could not bring it back in the moment.       |

## Pacing model (60 minutes)

| Part            | Time   | Per question       | Rule                                                                                                                                                           |
|-----------------|--------|--------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Part A (Q1–10)  | 15 min | about 1.5 min each | Bank all 50 points. Zero errors beats speed.                                                                                                                   |
| Part B (Q11–20) | 25 min | about 2.5 min each | Draw or tabulate before calculating.                                                                                                                           |
| Part C (Q21–25) | 15 min | about 3 min each   | Attempt every question; record cases.                                                                                                                          |
| Check           | 5 min  | —                  | Re-read the question for every answer you marked '?'.<br>Stuck for more than twice the per-question time? Mark it '?', move on, come back in the check window. |

**Stuck for more than twice the per-question time? Mark it '?', move on, come back in the check window.**